

play tells us nothing for certain about the child's own experiences (Ceci, 1995; Koocher et al., 1995).

Prospects for New Personality Tests

Each of the currently popular personality tests has limitations, but some psychologists are experimenting with creative new techniques. One approach that a few researchers have tried is the *emotional Stroop test*. Recall the Stroop effect from Chapter 8: People are asked to look at a display like this and read the color of the ink instead of reading the words:

purple brown green blue yellow purple yellow red brown

In the **emotional Stroop test**, a person examines a list of words, some of which relate to a possible source of worry or concern to the person, and tries to say the color of the ink of each word. For example, in the display below, say the color of the ink of each word as fast as possible:

TRY IT
YOUR-
SELF

cancer venom defeat hospital rattler failure fangs blood
loser slither nurses bite jobless cobra inadequate disease

As a rule, people who are known to have an anxiety about snakes have an extra-long delay in reading the color of snake-related words—*venom*, *rattler*, *fangs*, *slither*, *bite*, *cobra*. Similarly, people worried about their health have long delays on the disease-related words; people concerned about success and failure have delays on words like *loser* and *jobless*. Therefore, it is possible to measure people's delays in stating the ink color for a variety of words and from these results infer each person's main worries or concerns (Williams, Mathews, & MacLeod, 1996). Researchers are just beginning to explore the potential uses of this method.

CONCEPT CHECK

- On the preceding sample items of an emotional Stroop test, if you had the greatest delay in naming the ink color for *cancer*, *hospital*, *blood*, *nurses*, and *disease*, what would these results imply about your emotions? (Check your answer on page 513.)

Uses and Misuses of Personality Tests

Before any drug company can market a new drug in the United States, the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) requires that it be carefully tested. If the FDA finds the drug safe and effective, it approves the drug for certain purposes, with a warning label that lists precautions, such as an advisory that pregnant women should not take it. After the drug is approved, however, the FDA cannot prevent a physician from prescribing it for an unapproved purpose and cannot keep it out of the hands of people who should not be taking it.

Personality tests are a little like drugs: They ought to be used with great caution and only for the purposes for which they have demonstrable usefulness. They are, at a minimum, helpful to psychologists as an interviewing technique, to help “break the ice” and get a good conversation started. Tests can also be useful as an aid in personality assessment by a clini-

cal psychologist. Note that I said “as an aid,” *not* “as a sufficient method of personality assessment.” For example, suppose someone has an MMPI personality profile that resembles the profile typical for schizophrenia. Identifying schizophrenia or any other unusual condition is a signal-detection problem, as we discussed in Chapter 4—a problem of reporting a stimulus when it is present without falsely reporting it when it is absent. Suppose (realistically) that people without schizophrenia outnumber people with schizophrenia by 100 to 1. Suppose further that a particular personality profile on the MMPI-2 is characteristic of 95% of people with schizophrenia and only 5% of other people. As Figure 13.25 shows, 5% of the normal population is a *larger* group than 95% of the schizophrenic population. Thus, if we labeled as “schizophrenic” everyone with a high score, we would be wrong more often than right. (Recall the representativeness heuristic and the issue of base-rate information, discussed in Chapter 8: Someone who seems “representative” of people in a rare category does not necessarily belong to that category.) Therefore, a conscientious psychologist will

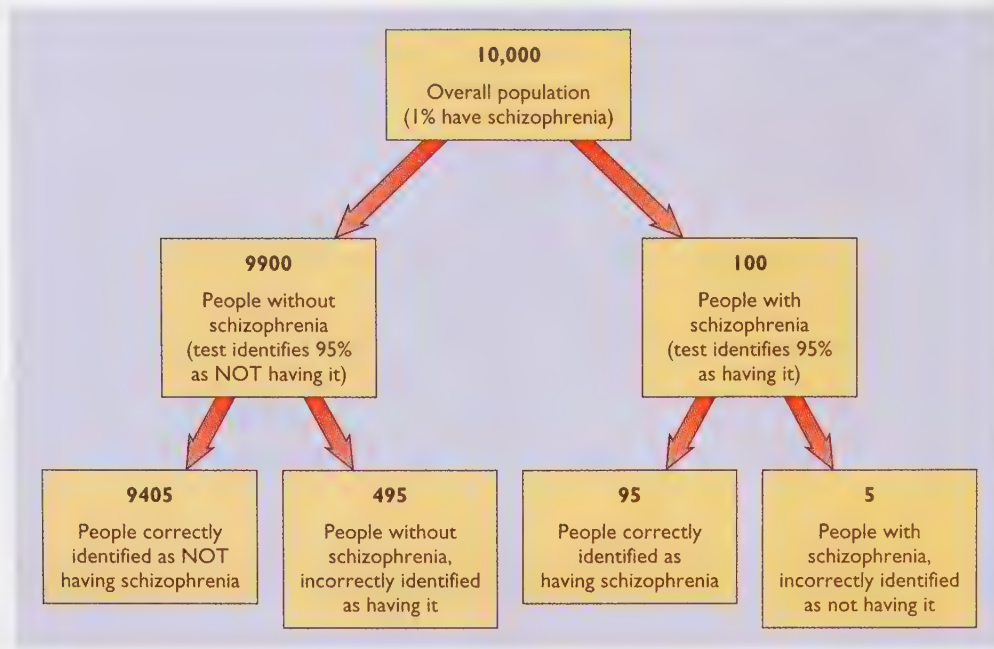


FIGURE 13.25 Even the best personality tests make mistakes. A test to detect an unusual condition will often identify normal people as having the condition. Here, we assume that a certain profile occurs in 95% of people with schizophrenia and 5% of other people. If we relied entirely on this test, we would correctly identify 95 schizophrenic people, but we would also misidentify 495 normal people as schizophrenic.

look for other evidence beyond the test score before drawing a firm conclusion. (The same, of course, should be said of any test, including IQ tests.)

Some employers use personality tests to screen job applicants, selecting only those who have the “right” personality. The underlying idea is correct: What makes a good worker is at least as much a matter of personality as it is intelligence. A good worker is conscientious, cooperative with other workers, calm under pressure, persistent about achieving goals, responsive to the client’s needs, and so forth—all personality traits. The difficulty is not that personality is unimportant but that many personality tests do not measure the right factors (Hogan, Hogan, & Roberts, 1996). For example, a personality test that claims to measure an “aggressive” personality may not measure the kind of aggressiveness that is presumably useful in a sales job. For ethical, legal, and practical reasons, employers should use a personality test *only* when they have clear evidence that the results help them to select among job applicants more accurately than they could without the test.

THE MESSAGE

Trying to Measure Personality

As you have been reading about personality tests, you may have objected that no test could adequately describe the factors that make you the unique individual that you are. You are right. Just try to imagine how long it would take to measure everything that is worth knowing about your personality. After all, even family members who have known you all your life are sometimes surprised by what you say and do.

The goals of personality testing are more modest—just to measure a few aspects that are useful for certain pur-

poses. But we need to remember what these purposes are and determine how well (or poorly) various tests can achieve them. Within their proper place tests can be useful; the problems arise when people try to draw strong conclusions from weak data.

S U M M A R Y

- ★ *People’s tendency to accept personality test results.* Because most people are inclined to accept almost any interpretation of their personality based on a personality test, tests must be carefully scrutinized to ensure that they are measuring what they claim to measure. (page 503)
- ★ *Standardized personality tests.* A standardized test is one that is administered according to explicit rules and whose results are interpreted in a prescribed fashion. Standards are based on the scores of people who have already taken the test. (page 504)
- ★ *The MMPI.* The MMPI, a widely used personality test, consists of a series of true-false questions selected in an effort to distinguish among various personality types. The MMPI-2 is a modernization of the version first developed in the 1940s. (page 504)
- ★ *Detection of lying.* The MMPI and certain other tests guard against lying by including items on which nearly all honest people will give the same answer. Any other answer is probably a lie. An unusual number of “lying” answers will invalidate the results. (page 505)
- ★ *The 16-PF Test.* The 16-PF Test, another standardized personality test, measures 16 personality traits. Although it was designed primarily to measure normal personality, its results do distinguish between normal and abnormal personalities. (page 506)
- ★ *Projective techniques.* A projective technique—such as the Rorschach Inkblots or the Thematic Apperception Test—lets people describe their concerns indirectly while

talking about “the person in the picture” or about other ambiguous stimuli. The results from projective techniques are difficult to interpret and have unimpressive validity for making decisions about any individual. (page 507)

★ **Uses and misuses of personality tests.** Personality tests can be used as an aid for assessing personality, but their results should be interpreted cautiously and in conjunction with other evidence. These tests should be used for job selection only when evidence clearly indicates that the results are valid for this purpose. (page 511)

Suggestion for Further Reading

Anastasi, A. (1988). *Psychological testing* (6th ed.). New York: Macmillan. A good textbook on both personality testing and IQ testing.

Terms

standardized test a test that is administered according to specified rules and whose scores are interpreted in a prescribed fashion (page 504)

Minnesota Multiphasic Personality Inventory (MMPI) a standardized test consisting of true-false items and intended to measure various personality dimensions and clinical conditions such as depression (page 504)

MMPI-2 the modernized edition of the MMPI (page 504)

16-PF Test a standardized personality test that measures 16 personality traits (page 506)

personality profile a graph that shows an individual's scores on scales measuring various personality traits (page 507)

projective techniques procedures designed to encourage people to project their personality characteristics onto ambiguous stimuli (page 508)

Rorschach Inkblots a projective personality technique; people are shown 10 inkblots and asked what each might be depicting (page 508)

Thematic Apperception Test (TAT) a projective personality technique; a person is asked to tell a story about each of 20 pictures (page 510)

Answers to Concept Checks

7. a. The puppet activity could be a projective technique, because the child is likely to project his or her own family concerns onto the puppets, using them to enact various problems. (page 508)
8. The Rorschach Inkblot Test must be administered in person by a psychologist who observes how you hold the cards, whether you rotate them, and anything else you do. The psychologist may also ask you to explain where you see something or why it looks as you say it does. (page 509)
9. The results would suggest that you are especially worried about health-related matters. (page 511)

Web Resources

Barbarian's Online Test Page

www.iglobal.net/psman/personality.html

The Barbarian provides links to dozens of sites that feature personality tests, including the Kiersey Temperament Sorter, the Enneagram Test, the Type A Personality Test, and the Locus of Control test. Additional tests can be found in the *Other Online Tests* section.*

*Note: Any psychological test that is readily available to the public, while entertaining and possibly informative, should not be used to make important decisions about yourself or others. The most powerful, valid, and reliable psychological assessment devices are usually kept under the tight control of their creators or copyright holders.

Social Psychology



14

★ MODULE 14.1

Social Perception and Cognition

First Impressions

Stereotypes and Prejudices

Overcoming Prejudice

Attribution

Internal Causes Versus External Causes / Errors and Biases / Using Attributions to Control Perceptions of Ourselves

★ MODULE 14.2

Attitudes and Persuasion

Attitudes and Their Influence

Two Routes of Attitude Change and Persuasion

Highly Resistant Attitudes / Delayed Influence of Messages / Ways of Presenting Persuasive Messages / Audience Variables

Strategies of Persuasion

Cognitive Dissonance

Evidence Favoring the Cognitive Dissonance Theory

★ MODULE 14.3

Interpersonal Attraction

People's Need for One Another

Establishing Lasting Relationships

Proximity and Familiarity / Similarity / Confirmation of Self-Concept / The Equity Principle

Special Concerns for Selecting a Mate

Physical Attractiveness

Romantic and Passionate Love

Romantic Relationships that Last

★ MODULE 14.4

Interpersonal Influence

Conformity

Accepting or Denying Responsibility Toward Others

Bystander Helpfulness and Apathy / Social Loafing

Group Decision-Making

Group Polarization / Groupthink

★ MODULE 14.5

The Power of the Social Situation

Behavior Traps

Cooperation and Competition in the Prisoner's

Dilemma / The Commons Dilemma / OBEDIENCE

TO AUTHORITY: WHAT'S THE EVIDENCE?

In the *Communist Manifesto*, Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels wrote, “Mankind are more disposed to suffer, while evils are sufferable, than to right themselves by abolishing the forms to which they are accustomed. But when a long train of abuses and usurpations, pursuing invariably the same object, evinces a design to reduce them under absolute despotism, it is their right, it is their duty, to throw off such government.” Fidel Castro wrote, “A little rebellion, now and then, is a good thing.”

Do you agree with those statements? Why or why not? Can you think of anything that would change your mind?

Oh, pardon me. . . . That first statement was not from the *Communist Manifesto*—it was from the United States’ Declaration of Independence. Sorry. And that second statement was a quotation from Thomas Jefferson, not Castro.

Do you agree more with these statements now that you know they came from democratic revolutionaries instead of communist revolutionaries? What determines who or what will influence you? This question is one example of the issues of interest to **social psychologists**—the *psychologists who study social behavior and how individuals influence other people and are influenced by other people*.

Social psychology is a broad, diverse field that is difficult to define. I know I have just defined it as the study of social behavior and influence, but the term *social behavior* is in turn defined very broadly to include such things as attitudes, persuasion, and certain aspects of self-understanding. One

characterization of social psychology, if not exactly a definition, is that it is a field that studies the everyday behaviors of relatively normal people, generally in relationship to other people. In this chapter, we shall consider several of the major fields of research and application in social psychology.



Social psychologists find that influence depends not only on what someone says, but also on who says it, and on what the listeners think of that person.

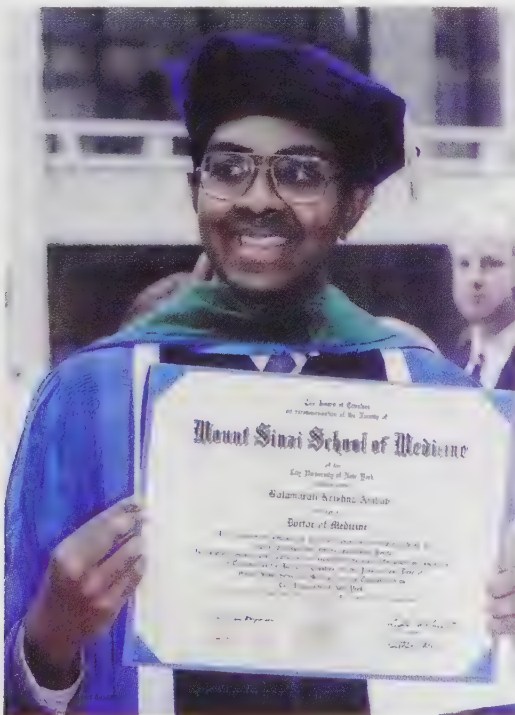
Social Perception and Cognition

How do we form impressions of other people?

How do we determine why someone behaves in a certain way?

Shortly after a massacre in Lebanon in 1982, several audiences were polled concerning their reactions to the television news coverage. Pro-Israeli audiences were angry about the news programs' anti-Israeli bias, whereas pro-Arab audiences were angry about the *same* programs' anti-Arab bias (Vallone, Ross, & Lepper, 1985).

We inevitably form attitudes about other people and



If you were a new patient of Dr. Balamurali Ambati, the world's youngest doctor (at age 17), what would your first impression probably be? If you formed a first impression based only on his youthful appearance, you could be badly mistaken about his abilities. First impressions do not always linger, but sometimes they do.

groups of people—whether good, bad, or indifferent. Once we have formed such attitudes, they can be very persistent, altering the way we perceive new information about those people. **Social perception and cognition** describe *the process we use to gather and remember information about others and to make inferences based on that information*. Social perception and cognition are similar in many ways to the principles of visual perception and nonsocial cognition that we examined in earlier chapters, particularly because our expectations can strongly influence what we observe, remember, and conclude.

First Impressions

Other things being equal, *the first information we learn about someone influences us more than later information does* (Belmore, 1987; Jones & Goethals, 1972). This tendency is known as the **primacy effect**. For example, if a professor seems energetic and engaging on the first day of class, you will start out with a favorable attitude and thus probably forgive his or her lackluster performance later in the semester. But a professor who seems dull from the first will have a hard time regaining your attention later in the semester. Similarly, your professors' early impressions of their students can have lasting effects. Also, think about the first impressions you formed of various fellow students and coworkers.

Why are first impressions so influential? Partly because, if our first impression of someone is unfavorable, we may not spend enough time with that person to form an alternative view. Also, once we have formed an impression, it alters our interpretation of later experiences. Suppose that your first impression of someone is that he talks about himself too much. Later, when he talks about himself again, even in a modest or appropriate way, you will take his comments as further support for your initial impression. Anything he says about someone else will merely seem like an "exception to the rule." Similarly, if your first impression of someone is unfavorable, when you walk past her and she says nothing, you will interpret her behavior as unfriendly. If your first impression had been favorable, you might interpret the same behavior as an indication that she was busy or distracted.

Thus, our first impressions can become self-fulfilling prophecies. For example, suppose a psychologist hands you a telephone receiver and invites you to have a conversation with an attractive, appealing person of the opposite sex. Later, the psychologist hands you the same receiver and invites you to talk with a person described as much less attractive. You will act very differently toward these two people and probably elicit cheerful, sparkling conversation from the first and rather bland conversation from the second—even though the two people were actually similar. (The psychologist chose at random which person would get which description; neither knew how the psychologist was

describing them.) In short, your first impression of someone changes how you act, and thereby influences the other person to try to live up to (or down to) your first impression (Snyder, Tanke, & Berscheid, 1977).

SOMETHING TO THINK ABOUT

In a criminal trial, the prosecution presents its evidence first. Might that give the jury an unfavorable first impression of the defendant and increase the probability of a conviction? ★

CONCEPT CHECK

1. Why do some professors avoid looking at students' names when they grade essay exams? Why is it more important for them to avoid looking at the names on tests given later in the semester than on the first test? (Check your answer on page 523.)

Stereotypes and Prejudices

A **stereotype** is a *generalized belief or expectation about a group of people*. We generally reserve the term **prejudice** for an *unfavorable stereotype, a negative attitude toward a group of people*, such as a belief that members of a particular group are lazy or hostile. Prejudices are frequently unyielding and harmful. For example, someone who has a prejudice against black people may not give blacks a fair chance to show their abilities. Black children who battle repeated instances of prejudice in school sometimes become so discouraged that they stop trying. For example, Claude Steele (1997) has found that, if black students are given a task but are told that it is not a test of their abilities, they perform well. But if they are told that the test will measure their abilities, many perform poorly. Steele's interpretation is that a test of abilities raises the threat that, if blacks perform poorly, they tend to confirm the hated prejudices about their abilities, and their concerns about that threat are counterproductive to their performance (Steele & Aronson, 1995).

Many stereotypes and prejudices are not only harmful but also false. False beliefs can emerge through a simple feature of human memory: We tend to remember the unusual. If we see an unusual person doing something unusual, the event is doubly memorable. For example, if you have met only a few left-handed redheads in your life, and maybe two of them did something unusual, you might remember those events and form a stereotype about left-handed redheads that might be entirely wrong—an illusory correlation, as discussed in Chapter 2.

Stereotypes can also be based on a grossly exaggerated grain of truth. In particular, people tend to perceive and describe their political opponents as being far more extreme than they really are (Keltner & Robinson, 1996). For example, some English-literature professors in the United States have been arguing for a revision of the curriculum to include

more feminist and non-Western writers. When defenders of the standard curriculum (Shakespeare, Homer, Chaucer, and so forth) were asked to guess what the revisionists really wanted, most guessed that the revisionists wanted students to read *nothing but* feminist and multicultural authors. In fact, the revisionists wanted a mixture of such authors along with some traditional choices (Robinson & Keltner, 1996).

Researchers have, however, belatedly discovered that stereotypes are sometimes correct. For example, who do you think are more aggressive, on the average—men or women? Who express their feelings more easily, on the average—men or women? If you answered “men” to the first question and “women” to the second, you expressed stereotypes, but the evidence says you are correct. Similarly, who do you think is more likely to be sensitive to the subtle social connotations of what people say—a liberal-arts major or an engineering major? Again, if you said “liberal-arts major,” you are endorsing a stereotype, but you are generally right (Ottati & Lee, 1995).

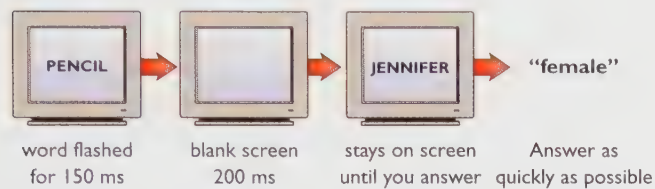
In some cases, two ethnic groups agree on a stereotype, although they put different values on it. For example, many Americans describe the Chinese as “inhibited,” whereas the Chinese would use the term “self-controlled.” U. S. businesspeople complain that Mexicans “don't show up on time for meetings and don't keep to schedules,” whereas the Mexicans complain that people in the United States “are always in a rush” and “act like robots” (Lee & Duenas, 1995). In short, it may be wrong to try to eliminate all stereotypes. Instead, we should try to gauge the accuracy of various stereotypes, and if groups do differ, accept those differences as part of the valuable, enjoyable diversity of human life. Further, even though we might recognize someone as a member of a group and therefore statistically more likely to behave in a particular way, we need to be able to readjust our expectation if it doesn't fit that individual. For example, it is natural to hold the stereotype that most 70-year-olds are less active and athletic than most 20-year-olds. But if I meet a 70-year-old woman who likes to play tennis, I should treat her as the active woman she is, not as mirroring my image of a typical 70-year-old.

It is easy to measure most attitudes by simply asking people to describe their attitudes or to put a check mark on an answer sheet. Stereotypes and prejudices are different, however. When people are asked how much racism they think occurs in the United States, most say they perceive “some” or “much” racism. But if asked whether they themselves are racist, almost everyone says “no.” Similarly, most people deny being sexist or holding stereotypes about any group. We all believe in fair treatment for everyone, or so we say. But if no one is a racist or a sexist and no one holds any stereotypes or has any prejudice, where is all the racism, sexism, and so forth coming from?

Psychologists can measure prejudice in subtle ways. For example, suppose you watch a videotape of several young men who are talking loudly although you cannot hear exactly what they are saying. After a while, one of them pushes another. Now, you are asked whether you think the push was

aggressive or playful. Do you think your decision would be influenced by whether the men were black or white? Many people *are* influenced, even if they think they would not be. If the man doing the pushing is either white or a well-dressed black man, most people guess “playful,” but if he is black and not neatly dressed, most guess “aggressive” (Banaji & Greenwald, 1994; Kunda & Thagard, 1996).

Imagine yourself in the following study to measure gender stereotypes: On each trial, a word will be flashed on a screen, then the screen will go blank, and then a name will be flashed on the screen. You don’t need to do anything about the first word, but when you see the name, you must identify it as either male or female. For example:



Even though you don’t have to do anything with the first word, you are sure to read it anyway. (It’s flashed on the same part of the screen as the name.) If the first word has definite male or female connotations, it will either increase or decrease your speed of identifying the gender of the name. For example, if the first word is KING, it will facilitate saying “male” after the name STEVE but inhibit saying “female” after the name JANE. The word PRINCESS would have the opposite effects.

So, what happens if we use words that are generally associated with either male or female stereotypes? On the following list, cover the items at the right. First read a word at the left, and then uncover the name to the right and, as quickly as possible, identify it as either male or female.

TRY IT YOURSELF

Prime Word	Name	Male or Female?
Athletic	Dave	
Birthday	Michael	
Sentimental	Nancy	
Gentle	Jack	
Vulgar	Judy	
Thorn	Sarah	
Ballet	José	
Briefcase	Karen	
Tattoo	Bob	
Sleep	Linda	
Gossip	Barbara	
Hostile	Maria	
Mildew	Brian	
Sewing	Frank	

The effect here is small, so you probably did not notice yourself responding faster to some names than others, but at least you get the idea of the experiment. Taking the mean of a large number of subjects, researchers found that people

identify a name as female about 8 ms faster if the priming word was stereotypically female (such as *sentimental* or *ballet*) than if it was stereotypically male (such as *vulgar* or *briefcase*). Similarly, people identified a name as male about 8 ms faster after a male than a female priming word (Blair & Banaji, 1996). Speeds were intermediate after neutral words such as *prairie* or *sleep*.

In a similar study, participants were shown word pairs such as *white—stubborn*, where the words *white* and *black* were understood to refer to white and black people, and subjects were asked to press one button if the connection could be true (as in *white—stubborn*) and another button if the connection was never true (as in *black—metallic*). On the average, people pressed the button slightly faster when the pairings were consistent with common stereotypes (as in *white—ambitious* or *black—musical*) than if they were reversed (as in *white—musical* or *black—ambitious*), even though people still answered “yes” (Dovidio, Evans, & Tyler, 1986).

So . . . what’s my point? Is it, “See, way down deep you really are a sexist or racist, you nasty so-and-so”? Not at all. Most of the people in these studies were well-meaning and doing their best to overcome stereotypes and prejudice, and they would be embarrassed to discover that they exhibited signs of them (Monteith, Devine, & Zuwerink, 1993). The point is that racism, sexism, and all the other -isms can operate without our awareness (Greenwald & Banaji, 1995). People sometimes argue that we should eliminate all preferential treatment for blacks, women, and other groups, and instead select among applicants “entirely on the basis of their qualifications.” The problem, according to the research just described, is that we may have prejudices and embrace stereotypes that we do not consciously recognize. Even when we think we are looking just at the qualifications, we may actually look at these differently, depending on whether the person we are considering is white or black, male or female.

Overcoming Prejudice

After prejudices and hostility have arisen between two groups, what can anyone do to break down those barriers? Simply getting to know each other better sometimes helps, but not dependably. A more effective technique is to get the two groups to work toward a common goal.

Many years ago, psychologists demonstrated the power of this technique using two arbitrarily chosen groups, not different races (Sherif, 1966). At a summer camp at Robbers’ Cave, Oklahoma, 11-to-12-year-old boys were divided into two groups in separate cabins. The groups competed for prizes in sports, treasure hunts, and other activities. With each competition, the antagonism between the two groups grew more intense. The boys made threatening posters, shouted insults, and engaged in food fights. Each group had clearly developed prejudice and hostility toward the other.

Up to a point, the “counselors” (the experimenters) allowed the hostility to take its course, neither encouraging



People who work together for a common goal can overcome prejudices that initially divide them.

nor prohibiting it. Then, they tried to reverse it by stopping the competitions and setting common goals. First, they asked the two groups to work together to find and repair a leak in the water pipe that supplied the camp. Later, they had the two groups pool their treasuries to rent a movie that both groups wanted to see. Still later, they had the boys pull together to get a truck out of a rut. Gradually, hostility turned into friendship—except for a few holdouts who nursed their hatred to the bitter end! The point of this study is that competition leads to hostility; cooperation leads to friendship.

Attribution

We often try to figure out why the people we observe behave as they do. Yesterday, you won 1 million dollars in the state lottery. Today, a classmate who had never seemed to notice you before asks you for a date. You wonder why. When we are not sure what is causing the behavior of someone we are observing, we *attribute* causes that seem appropriate. **Attribution** is the set of thought processes we use to assign causes to our own behavior and to the behavior of others.

Internal Causes Versus External Causes

Fritz Heider, the founder of attribution theory, maintained that people often try to decide whether someone's behavior is the result of internal or external causes (Heider, 1958). **Internal attributions** are explanations based on someone's stable characteristics, such as attitudes, personality traits, or abilities. **External attributions** are explanations based on the situation, such as stimuli in the environment, the events of the day, and the rewards and penalties associated with certain acts. For example, your brother decides to walk to work this morning instead of driving. You could offer an internal attribution ("He likes fresh air and exercise") or an external attribution ("His car is broken"). Internal attributions are also known as *dispositional*; external attributions are also known as *situational*.

We make internal attributions when someone does something unexpected—something that makes us say, "I wouldn't have done that." For example, if I told you I would like to visit Hawaii, you would draw no conclusions about me, because the appeal of Hawaii is obvious. However, if I said I would like to visit Antarctica, you would wonder what about me could explain this unusual interest (Krull & Anderson, 1997).

This tendency sometimes leads to misunderstandings between members of different cultures. Each person views the other's behavior as "something I would not have done" and therefore grounds for making an attribution about the other individual's personality. In fact, such behavior may actually be what the other person's culture dictates. For example, some cultures expect people to cry loudly at funerals or to be emotionally demonstrative in other ways; other cultures expect people to be more restrained under these circumstances. People who are unfamiliar with other cultures may attribute a behavior to someone's personality and thus overlook the influence of the situation and the culturally determined response to that situation.

Harold Kelley (1967) proposed the theory that we rely on three types of information when deciding whether to make an internal or an external attribution for someone's behavior:

- **Consensus information** (how a person's behavior compares with other people's behavior). If someone be-



We are sometimes surprised by people's behavior and attribute an internal cause when in fact the people are acting in accord with the customs of their culture.



haves the same way that other people do in a situation, or the same way you imagine other people would, then you would probably make an external attribution. If someone behaves in an unusual way, you look for an internal attribution, pertaining to something about that person instead of something about the situation.

- **Consistency information** (*how the person's behavior varies from one time to the next*). If someone almost always seems friendly, for example, you would make an internal attribution ("this person is friendly"). If someone seems friendly at times and less friendly at other times, you look for external attributions ("something just happened to cause this person's bad mood").

- **Distinctiveness** (*how the person's behavior varies from one object or social partner to another*). For example, if someone is friendly to most people, but unfriendly to one particular person, you make an external attribution for the unfriendly behavior. That is, you assume that person elicits unfriendly behavior from an otherwise friendly person and that, therefore, the behavior does not reveal a personality trait.

CONCEPT CHECKS

2. Classify the following as either internal or external attributions:
 - a. She contributed money to charity because she is generous.
 - b. She contributed money to charity because she wanted to impress her boss, who was watching.
 - c. She contributed money to charity because she owed a favor to the man who was asking for contributions.
3. Your friend Juanita returns from watching *The Return of the Son of Sequel Strikes Back Again Part 2* and says it was excellent. Most other people who commented on this film disliked it. Will you be inclined to make an internal or an external attribution for Juanita's enjoyment of this movie? Why? (Distinctiveness, consensus, or consistency?) (Check your answers on page 523.)

Errors and Biases

In most cases, people judge the evidence intelligently and make appropriate internal or external attributions for people's behavior. However, one error they are especially likely to make is *to make internal attributions for other people's behavior, even when they see evidence for an external influence on behavior*. That tendency is known as the **fundamental attribution error** (Ross, 1977).

For example, students in one study were asked to read an essay that another student had written, praising Fidel Castro, the Communist leader of Cuba, and then estimate the writer's actual attitudes toward Castro. Even students who were told that the writer had been assigned to write a pro-Castro essay assumed that the writer was at least mildly pro-Castro (Jones & Harris, 1967). In a later study, experi-

menters explained that one student in a creative writing class had been assigned to write a pro-Castro essay and an anti-Castro essay, at different times in the course. They then showed the subjects the two essays and asked them to estimate the writer's true beliefs. Most said they thought that the writer had significantly changed his or her attitudes toward Castro between the first essay and the second (Allison, Mackie, Muller, & Worth, 1993). That is, even when people are told of a powerful external reason for someone's behavior, they still sometimes make internal attributions. Apparently, they believe that the situational pressure could not have been sufficient and that the person must have had internal reasons as well (McClure, 1998).

Moreover, *people are more likely to make internal attributions for other people's behavior than they are for their own behavior* (Jones & Nisbett, 1972). This tendency is called the **actor-observer effect**. You are an "actor" when you try to explain the causes of your own behavior and an "observer" when you try to explain someone else's behavior.

The actor-observer effect has been demonstrated in several studies (Watson, 1982). In one of these, Richard Nisbett and his colleagues (1973) asked college students to rate themselves, their fathers, their best friends, and Walter Cronkite (a television news announcer at the time) on several personality traits. For each trait (such as "leniency"), the subjects were given three choices: (1) the person possesses the trait, (2) the person possesses the opposite trait, and (3) the person's behavior "depends on the situation." Subjects checked "depends on the situation"—an external attribution—most frequently when they were rating themselves, less frequently when they were rating their fathers and friends, and least often when they were rating Walter Cronkite. Figure 14.1 shows the results.

Why do we tend to explain our own behavior differently from that of others? There are several possibilities (Jones & Nisbett, 1972; Watson, 1982). *First*, because we observe our own behavior in many different situations, we realize how much it varies from one situation to another. (Recall Kelley's theory: You make external attributions when someone's behavior varies across time and across situations.) We are less aware of the variations in someone else's behavior.

Second, we tend to attribute unexpected, surprising behavior to internal causes. Our own behavior seldom surprises us, so we do not attribute it to internal causes.

The *third* reason is perceptual. We do not see ourselves as objects, because our eyes look outward and focus on our environment. We see other people, however, as objects in our visual field.

The perceptual explanation for the actor-observer effect has an interesting implication: If you could somehow become an object in your own visual field, then you might explain your own behavior in terms of internal traits, just as you tend to explain the behavior of others. In one innovative study, Michael Storms (1973) videotaped several subjects as they carried on a conversation. Before showing them the videotape, he asked them why they had said certain things

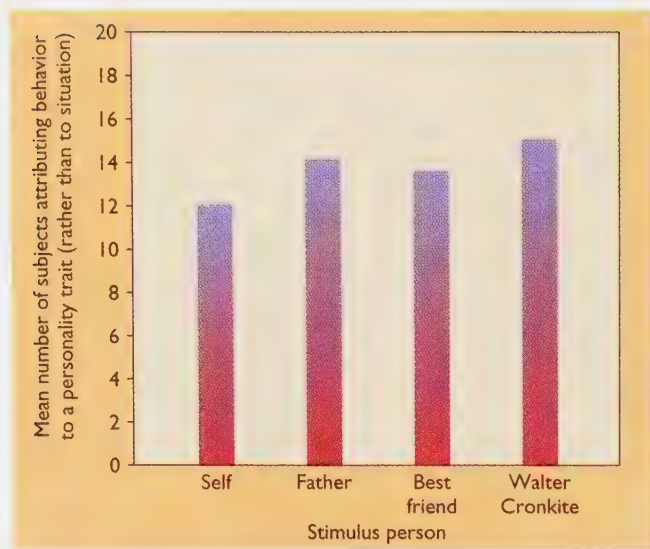


FIGURE 14.1 Subjects were asked whether certain people had certain traits, such as “leniency,” or the opposite traits, such as “firmness,” or whether “it depended on the situation.” They attributed the most personality traits to news announcer Walter Cronkite (the person they knew least) and the fewest to themselves. That is, they were most likely to say that their own behavior depended on the situation. (Based on data of Nisbett, Caputo, Legant, & Marecek, 1973.)

and why they thought the others had said what they had. At first, most of the subjects attributed their own remarks to external causes (“I was responding to what the other person said”) and attributed what the other people had said to internal causes “he was showing off” or “she always says things like that”). Then Storms showed them the videotape and asked them the same questions. This time, many of them attributed their own behavior more often to internal causes (“I was being smart-alecky. . . . I was trying to act friendly”). That is, when people watched themselves, they reacted just as they did when watching other people—by making mostly internal attributions for behavior.

SOMETHING TO THINK ABOUT

Try to explain these examples of behavior:

- Why did you choose to go to the college you are attending?
- Why did your roommate choose this college?
- Why are you reading this book right now?
- Why does your roommate study so much (or so little)?

Did you attribute internal causes or external causes for these behaviors? Did you rely more on external causes to explain other people’s behavior or to explain your own? *

Using Attributions to Control Perceptions of Ourselves

Although we generally attribute our own behavior largely to external causes, we vary our attributions to try to pre-

sent ourselves in a favorable light. For example, you may credit your intelligence for the good grades you get (an internal attribution) and blame unfair tests for your bad grades (an external attribution). Members of groups that are frequent victims of discrimination often blame their defeats on prejudice and discrimination—sometimes rightly, sometimes wrongly (Crocker & Major, 1989). *Attributions that we adopt to maximize our credit for our success and minimize our blame for our failure* are called **self-serving biases** (Miller & Ross, 1975; Van Der Pligt & Eiser, 1983).

People can also protect their image by adopting **self-handicapping strategies**, when they *intentionally put themselves at a disadvantage to provide an excuse for an expected failure*. Suppose you expect to do poorly on a final exam. You go to a party the night before and stay out until three in the morning. Now, you can blame your low score on your lack of sleep and avoid having to admit even to yourself that you might have done poorly anyway.

In an experiment on self-handicapping strategies, Steven Berglas and Edward Jones (1978) asked college students to work on problems; some students were given solvable problems, and others were given a mixture of solvable and unsolvable problems. Then, the experimenters told all the students that they had done well. The students who had been given solvable problems (and had solved them) felt good about their success. Those who had worked on unsolvable problems were unsure in what way they had “done well,” because they knew they had not understood many of the problems. They certainly had no confidence that they could continue to do well.

Next, the experimenters told the subjects that the purpose of the experiment was to investigate the effects of drugs on problem solving and that they were now going to hand out another set of problems. The subjects could choose between taking a drug that supposedly impaired problem solving abilities and another drug that supposedly improved them. The subjects who had worked on unsolvable problems the first time were more likely than the others to choose the drug that supposedly impaired performance. Because they did not expect to do well on the second set of problems anyway, they chose to provide themselves with a convenient excuse.

THE MESSAGE

How Social Perceptions Affect Behavior

We are seldom fully aware of the reasons for our own behavior, much less someone else’s, but we make our best guesses. If someone you know passes by without saying hello, you might attribute that person’s behavior to either absentmindedness, indifference, or outright hostility. If someone acts unusually friendly, you might attribute that response to your own personal charm, the other person’s

extraverted personality, or that person's devious and manipulative personality. Whatever attributions you make are sure to influence your own social behaviors.

S U M M A R Y

- ★ *First impressions.* Other things being equal, we pay more attention to the first information we learn about someone than to later information. (page 517)
- ★ *Stereotypes.* Stereotypes are generalized beliefs about groups of people. They are sometimes illusory correlations that arise from people's tendency to remember unusual actions clearly, especially unusual actions by members of minority groups. However, some stereotypes are also correct or partly correct. (page 518)
- ★ *Prejudice.* A prejudice is an unfavorable stereotype. Many people will not admit, even to themselves, that they have prejudices. Through indirect measures, researchers have found ways to demonstrate subtle effects of stereotypes and prejudices even in people who deny having them. (page 518)
- ★ *Attribution.* Attribution is the set of thought processes by which we assign causes to behavior. We attribute behavior either to internal causes or to external causes. According to Harold Kelley, we are likely to attribute behavior to an internal cause if it is consistent over time, different from most other people's behavior, and directed toward a variety of other people or objects. (page 520)
- ★ *Fundamental attribution error.* People frequently attribute other people's behavior to internal causes, even when they see evidence of external influences. (page 521)
- ★ *Actor-observer effect.* We are more likely to attribute internal causes to other people's behavior than to our own. (page 521)
- ★ *Self-serving bias and self-handicapping.* People sometimes try to protect their self-esteem by attributing their successes to skill and their failures to outside influences. They can also intentionally place themselves at a disadvantage to provide an excuse for their expected failure. (page 522)

Suggestion for Further Reading

M. P. Zanna & J. M. Olson (Eds.) (1994). *The psychology of prejudice: The Ontario Symposium, Volume 7*. Hillsdale, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum. Good collection of research on stereotypes and prejudices.

Terms

- social psychologists** the psychologists who study social behavior and how individuals influence other people and are influenced by other people (page 516)
- social perception and cognition** the process of gathering and remembering information about others and making inferences based on that information (page 517)

- primacy effect** the tendency to be more influenced by the first information learned about someone than by later information about the same person (page 517)
- stereotypes** overgeneralizations of either positive or negative attitudes toward people (page 518)
- prejudice** an unfavorable stereotype; a negative attitude toward a group of people (page 518)
- attribution** the set of thought processes we use to assign causes to our own behavior and to the behavior of others (page 520)
- internal attribution** an explanation based on someone's stable characteristics, such as attitudes, personality traits, or abilities (page 520)
- external attribution** an explanation based on the situation, such as stimuli in the environment, the events of the day, and the rewards and penalties associated with certain acts (page 520)
- consensus information** comparisons of one person's behavior with that of others (page 520)
- consistency information** observations of how a person's behavior varies from one time to another (page 521)
- distinctiveness** observations of how a person's behavior varies from one object or social partner to another (page 521)
- fundamental attribution error** the tendency to make internal attributions for other people's behavior, even when an observer sees evidence for an external influence (page 521)
- actor-observer effect** the tendency to attribute internal causes more often for other people's behavior than for one's own behavior (page 521)
- self-serving biases** attributions that people adopt to maximize their credit for their successes and to minimize their blame for their failures (page 522)
- self-handicapping strategies** techniques for intentionally putting oneself at a disadvantage to provide an excuse for an expected failure (page 522)

Answers to Concept Checks

1. They want to avoid being biased by their first impressions of the students. This procedure is less important with the first test, because they have not yet formed strong impressions of the students. (page 518)
2. **a.** internal; **b.** and **c.** external. An internal attribution relates to a stable aspect of personality or attitudes; an external attribution relates to the current situation. (page 521)
3. You will probably make an internal attribution for Juanita's enjoyment, attributing it to her characteristic of being easy to please instead of attributing it to the quality of the movie. The reason is *consensus*: When one person's behavior differs from that of others, we make an internal attribution. (page 521)

Web Resources

Interpersonal Perception

nw3.nai.net/~dakenny/interp.htm

David A. Kenny of the University of Connecticut, author of *Interpersonal Perception: A Social Relations Analysis*, offers an outstanding tutorial on the judgments that one person makes about another.

Attitudes and Persuasion

What are attitudes?

What methods of persuasion are most effective, and under what circumstances?

If you want to change people's behavior, first you have to change their attitudes." Do you agree?

Suppose you say "yes." Now, answer two more questions: (1) What is your attitude about paying higher taxes? (2) If the government raises taxes, will you pay the higher taxes?

If you're like most people, you will say that (1) your attitude about paying higher taxes is unfavorable, but that (2) if the taxes are raised, you will pay them. In other words, by changing the law, the government can change your behavior without changing your attitude.

So what effects do attitudes have on behavior? And what leads people to change their attitudes?

Attitudes and Their Influence

An **attitude** is a like or dislike that influences our behavior toward a person or thing (Allport, 1935; Petty & Cacioppo, 1981). Your attitudes include an evaluative or emotional component (how you feel about something), a cognitive component (what you know or believe), and a behavioral component (what you are likely to do). *Persuasion* is an attempt to alter your attitudes or behavior.

One common way of measuring attitudes (and thus the effectiveness of persuasion) is through the use of attitude scales, such as Likert scales, also known as summated rating scales (Dawes & Smith, 1985). On a Likert scale (named after psychologist Rensis Likert), a person checks a point along a line ranging from 1, meaning "strongly disagree," to 5 or 7, meaning "strongly agree," for each of several statements about a topic, as shown in Figure 14.2.

Check marks on an answer sheet are imperfect measurements of attitudes, partly because people have different styles of responding. For example, Japanese and Chinese people tend to put their check marks at or near the middle of the scale, whereas people in the United States tend to choose more extreme values (Chen, Lee, & Stevenson, 1995). Therefore, a check mark of 1 may not have quite the same meaning on an Asian answer sheet as it does on a North American answer sheet.

Even if we measure attitudes well, they do not always correlate strongly with actual behavior (McGuire, 1985; Wicker, 1969). For example, your favorable attitude toward getting good grades is no guarantee that you will devote yourself to your studies.

The behavior of some people is more consistent with

Indicate your level of agreement with the items below, using the following scale:

	Strongly disagree		Neutral		Strongly agree
1. Labor unions are necessary to protect the rights of workers.	1	2	3	4	5
2. Labor union leaders have too much power.	1	2	3	4	5
3. If I worked for a company with a union, I would join the union.	1	2	3	4	5
4. I would never cross a picket line of striking workers.	1	2	3	4	5
5. Striking workers hurt their company and unfairly raise prices for the consumer.	1	2	3	4	5
6. Labor unions should not be permitted to engage in political activity.	1	2	3	4	5
7. America is a better place for today's workers because of the efforts by labor unions in the past.	1	2	3	4	5

Note: Items 2, 5, and 6 are scored the opposite of 1, 3, 4, and 7.

FIGURE 14.2 Likert scales—such as this one assessing attitudes toward labor unions—are commonly used in attitude research. Subjects rate the degree to which they agree or disagree with items that measure various aspects of a particular attitude.

their attitudes than is the behavior of others. When you enter an unfamiliar situation, do you immediately look around to determine what other people are doing and what is expected of you? Some do. These people are known as **high self-monitors** because they *constantly monitor their own behavior to try to behave in the appropriate manner* (Snyder, 1979). Other people, *low self-monitors*, pay less attention to others' expectations and simply do what they feel like doing.

CONCEPT CHECK

4. Whose behavior matches their attitudes more closely—high self-monitors or low self-monitors? (Check your answer on page 533.)

Two Routes of Attitude Change and Persuasion

Remember from Chapter 2 that many of the people responding to one survey said “no” to *I believe there is intelligent life in outer space* and “yes” to *I believe the government is concealing evidence of intelligent life in outer space*. The most likely explanation is that people answer survey questions impulsively without thinking through their answers. The same is true of attitudes: Sometimes people ponder the evidence carefully and develop a carefully reasoned attitude, and sometimes they form attitudes with only a flimsy, superficial basis.

Richard Petty and John Cacioppo (1981, 1986) proposed the following distinction: *When people take a decision seriously, they invest the necessary time and effort to carefully evaluate the evidence and logic behind each message*. Petty and Cacioppo call this logical approach the **central route to persuasion**. In contrast, *when people listen to a message on a topic of little importance to them, they pay more attention to such factors as the speaker's appearance and reputation or the sheer number of arguments presented, regardless of their quality*. This superficial approach is the **peripheral route to persuasion**.

CONCEPT CHECK

5. You are listening to someone who is trying to persuade you to change your major from astrology to psychology. Your future success may depend on making the right decision. You also listen to someone explain why a trip to the Bahamas is better than a trip to the Fiji Islands. You had no intention of going to either place. In which case will you follow the central route to persuasion? (Check your answer on page 533.)



Most political candidates will try both the central and peripheral routes to persuasion, depending on the situation. In debate and interviews, they try to impress with their knowledge and logic. In brief campaign appearances, they are more concerned with presenting an image, such as that of a “regular person just like you.”

Highly Resistant Attitudes

Most people's attitudes fall along a continuum: You know much and care deeply about a few topics; regarding these, you have firm, well-informed attitudes that you would change only by solid evidence and logic—the central route. At the other end of the continuum, many topics hardly interest you at all; you might express an opinion, if asked, but you have little basis for that opinion, so you could change it easily, even by the peripheral route.

On a few topics, however, many people form strong, unshakable attitudes based on hardly any information at all. One such topic is the death penalty. In the United States, about 60–75% say that they support the death penalty, whereas 20–30% oppose it, and the others are undecided. The percentages vary a bit from year to year, but unlike most other topics, the answers hardly change at all after the question has been reworded (Ellsworth & Gross, 1994).

TRY IT YOURSELF

Before we continue, answer the following questions:

Knowledge items

1. The death penalty has been abolished by a majority of Western European nations.

True

☐

I don't know

☐

False

☐

2. Over the years, states which have had the death penalty have shown lower murder rates than neighboring states which did not have the death penalty.
- True ☐ I don't know ☐ False ☐
3. Studies have shown that the rate of murder usually drops in the weeks following a publicized execution.
- True ☐ I don't know ☐ False ☐
4. Poor people who commit murder are more likely to be sentenced to death than rich people.
- True ☐ I don't know ☐ False ☐
5. After the U.S. Supreme Court struck down the death penalty in 1972, the murder rate in the United States showed a sharp upturn.
- True ☐ I don't know ☐ False ☐
6. On the average, the death penalty costs the taxpayers less than life imprisonment.
- True ☐ I don't know ☐ False ☐

Reasons for support or opposition

1. We need capital punishment to provide support and protection for the police.
- Agree ☐ I don't know ☐ Disagree ☐
2. Even when a murderer gets a life sentence, he usually gets out on parole, so it is better to execute him.
- Agree ☐ I don't know ☐ Disagree ☐
3. We need capital punishment to show criminals that we mean business about wiping out crime in this country.
- Agree ☐ I don't know ☐ Disagree ☐
4. Society has a right to get revenge when a very serious crime like murder has been committed.
- Agree ☐ I don't know ☐ Disagree ☐

5. Sometimes I have felt a sense of personal outrage when a convicted murderer was sentenced to a penalty less than death.
- Agree ☐ I don't know ☐ Disagree ☐
6. One problem with the death penalty is that only the poor and unfortunate are likely to be executed.
- Agree ☐ I don't know ☐ Disagree ☐
7. There is too much danger of executing an innocent man.
- Agree ☐ I don't know ☐ Disagree ☐
8. Executions set a violent example which may even encourage violence and killing in our society.
- Agree ☐ I don't know ☐ Disagree ☐
9. It is immoral for society to take a life regardless of the crime the individual has committed.
- Agree ☐ I don't know ☐ Disagree ☐
10. Any execution would make me sad, regardless of the crime the individual had committed.
- Agree ☐ I don't know ☐ Disagree ☐

For the knowledge items, the correct answers are: (1) true, (2) false, (3) false, (4) true, (5) false, and (6) false. When these questions were asked of 500 Californians, the average person said "uncertain" to 1.5 of these 6 items, and answered 2.4 correctly and 2.0 incorrectly (Ellsworth & Ross, 1983). However, most said that, even if their guesses on these items and others were wrong, they couldn't imagine any facts that would change their attitude. Regarding the reasons for support or opposition, many people agreed with all or almost all of the reasons supporting their attitude and none of those against it.

You can see the difficulties of trying to persuade people, or even to arrange a compromise, on highly divisive issues such as the death penalty or abortion. People adopt a position and then accept any argument that favors it, and they reject or ignore any contrary information or argument.

Much is at stake here. In U.S. states that have instituted the death penalty, anyone who says "I could never vote for the death penalty under any circumstances" is excluded from jury service on a murder trial, because he or she cannot abide by the laws that state that a jury should consider the death penalty under certain circumstances.

Because many opponents of the death penalty say that they are opposed under *all* circumstances, trial juries in murder cases are composed almost entirely of death-penalty supporters—who are more often white than black, male than female, old than young, and more sympathetic to the prosecution than to the defense (Cowan, Thompson, & Ellsworth, 1984; Fitzgerald & Ellsworth, 1984).

Delayed Influence of Messages

In certain cases, a message may have no apparent influence on you at the time you hear it, but an important effect later. There are several reasons for a message to have a delayed effect; we shall consider two examples.

The Sleeper Effect Suppose you reject a message because of peripheral route influences. For example, you reject a new idea without giving it much thought, because you have a low opinion of the person who suggested it. If the idea is a good one, it may have a delayed effect. Weeks or months later, you may forget where you heard the idea and remember only the idea itself; at that time you can evaluate it on its merits (Hovland & Weiss, 1951; Pratkanis, Greenwald, Leippe, & Baumgardner, 1988). Psychologists use the term **sleeper effect** to describe *delayed persuasion by an initially rejected message*.

Minority Influence Delayed influence also occurs when a minority group, especially one that is not widely respected, proposes a worthwhile idea: The majority may reject the idea at first but adopt it later in some form. By “minority group,” I do not necessarily mean an ethnic minority; the minority may be a political minority or any other out-numbered group.

If a minority group continually repeats a single, simple message and its members seem to be united, it has a good chance of eventually influencing the majority's decision. The minority's united, uncompromising stance is important; it forces the majority to wonder, “Why won't these people conform? Maybe their idea is better than we thought.” The minority's influence often increases gradually, even if the majority hesitates to admit that the minority has swayed them (Wood, Lundgren, Ouellette, Busceme, & Blackstone, 1994). A minority, by expressing its views, can also prompt the majority to generate new ideas of its own (Nemeth, 1986). That is, by demonstrating the possibility of disagreement, the minority opens the way for other people to offer new suggestions that are different from the original views of both the majority and the minority.

One powerful example of minority influence is that of the Socialist Party of the United States, which ran candidates for elective offices from 1900 through the 1950s. The party never received more than 6% of the vote in any presidential election. No Socialist candidate was ever elected senator or governor, and only a few were elected to the



A persistent and determined group can exert major influences on public policy, with or without an election. Here, a woman waves as she climbs a redwood tree to protest logging in a California forest. Tree sitters sometimes stay in the treetops for days to prevent the cutting of trees.

House of Representatives (Shannon, 1955). Beginning in the 1930s, the party's membership and support began to dwindle, until eventually the party stopped nominating candidates.

Was that because the Socialists had failed? No. It was because they had already accomplished most of their original goals! Most of the major points in the party's 1900 platform had been enacted into law (see Table 14.1). Of course, the Democrats and Republicans who voted for these changes always claimed that the ideas were their own. Still, the Socialist Party, though always a minority, had exerted an enormous influence on the country.

CONCEPT CHECK

6. At a meeting of your student government, you suggest a new method of testing and grading students. The other members immediately reject your plan. Should you become discouraged and give up? If not, what should you do? (Check your answer on page 533.)

Ways of Presenting Persuasive Messages

Most persuasive messages fall into one of two categories—do this to make something good happen, and do this to prevent something bad from happening. Either one can be effective, depending on the circumstances. Figure 14.3

TABLE 14.1 The Political Platform of the U.S. Socialist Party, 1900

PROPOSAL	EVENTUAL FATE OF PROPOSAL
Women's right to vote	Established by 19th amendment to U.S. Constitution; ratified in 1920
Old-age pensions	Included in the Social Security Act of 1935
Unemployment insurance	Included in the Social Security Act of 1935; also guaranteed by other state and federal legislation
Health and accident insurance	Included in part in the Social Security Act of 1935 and in the Medicare Act of 1965
Increased wages, including minimum wage	First minimum-wage law passed in 1938; periodically updated since then
Reduction of working hours	Maximum 40-hour work week (with exceptions) established by the Fair Labor Standards Act of 1938
Public ownership of electric, gas, and other utilities and of the means of transportation and communication	Utilities not owned by government but heavily regulated by federal and state governments since the 1930s
Initiative, referendum, and recall (mechanisms for private citizens to push for changes in legislation and for removal of elected officials)	Adopted by most state governments

SOURCES: Foster, 1968; and Leuchtenburg, 1963.

shows a chain letter that has been circulated widely throughout the world over several decades. It has been called a “mind virus” because of its ability to get people to duplicate and spread the letter (Goodenough & Dawkins, 1994). Many people who receive this letter cannot resist its command to make copies and send them to others, even if they regard its message as a silly superstition. The letter claims to be offering “good luck” and “love,” but it follows those promises with an implied threat: Allegedly, people who have failed to follow the instructions have been victims of terrible events. (They lost their job, lost a loved one, died,

or had car problems!) The threat makes people feel nervous and uneasy if they decline to follow the instructions.

Fear messages are effective in some cases, as in the St. Jude letter, but not always. Appeals for money are often accompanied by implied threats, such as “If you don’t send enough money to support our cause, then our political opponents will gain power and do terrible things.” According to the research, messages that appeal to fear are effective only if they can convince people that the danger is real (Leventhal, 1970). People tend to disbelieve an organization that exaggerates the threats or sends “emergency” appeals too often.

Moreover, a fear message is most effective if people believe they can do something to reduce the danger, especially if they need to act only on rare occasions. For example, most people will visit a physician to get an immunization against a contagious disease or to get an X ray to test for cancer. Many people will also change their sex habits to avoid herpes or AIDS, but not everyone remains consistent in these practices. Even fewer people consistently change their behavior to conserve natural resources or to avoid damaging the world’s climate, because most people doubt that their behavior will exert a major influence.

Audience Variables

Some people are more easily persuaded than others are, and an individual may be more easily influenced at some times than at others. The ease of persuading someone depends on both person variables and situation variables.

Person Variables Who would you guess would be persuaded more easily—highly intelligent or less intelligent

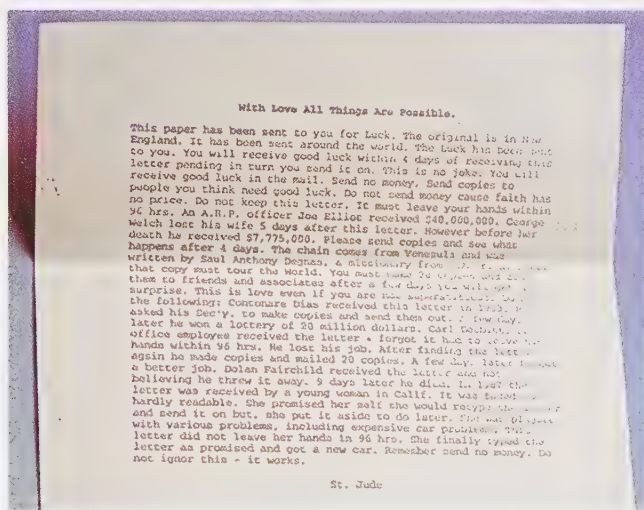


FIGURE 14.3 If you received a copy of this chain letter, would you copy it and send it on to other people, as it requests? Why or why not?

people? Actually, the answer depends on the message. Other things being equal, the peripheral route to persuasion is generally more effective with less intelligent people, who are more likely to accept an illogical or poorly supported idea (Eagly & Warren, 1976). The central route to persuasion is generally more effective with highly intelligent people, who are better able to understand complicated evidence and more likely to devote the energy necessary to evaluate it.

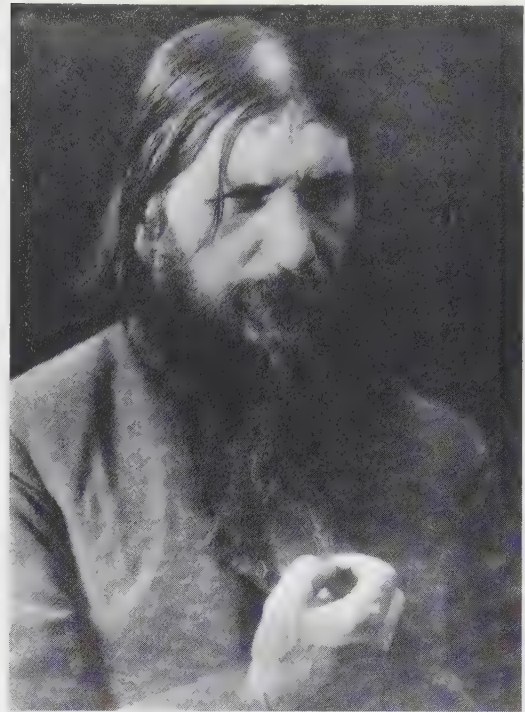
However, the effectiveness of the central or peripheral route depends not only on the listener's intelligence but also his or her level of interest. Suppose you listen to a debate about raising the tuition at Santa Enigma Junior College to pay for new buildings and equipment. You have never heard of the college, so you pay little attention. A neatly dressed, smooth-talking speaker can probably persuade you, using the peripheral route, even though you are an intelligent, well-educated person. But now imagine that you listen to a debate about raising tuition at your own college. The speaker could be the same, stating the same evidence and arguments, but you will now evaluate the arguments much more carefully, and the central route to persuasion will be more effective for you.

Situation Variables Other things being equal, a persuasive message is more effective if the speaker can convey the message, “I am similar to you” or “my message is right for people like you.” We like people who resemble ourselves in almost any way. In one striking illustration of this tendency, students were asked to read a very unflattering description of Grigory Rasputin, the “mad monk of Russia,” and then rate Rasputin's personality on several scales such as pleasant to unpleasant, effective to ineffective, and strong to weak. All students read the same description except for Rasputin's birthdate: In some cases, Rasputin's actual birthdate had been changed to match the student's own birthdate. Students who thought Rasputin had the same birthdate as their own liked him better than other students did. Nobody thought he was “pleasant,” but many did rate him as “strong” and “effective” (Finch & Cialdini, 1989).

You can probably think of examples where a speaker began by stressing his or her resemblance to the audience: “I remember when I was a student like you.” “I grew up in a town similar to this one.” “I believe in family values, and I'm sure you do too.” This technique is part of the peripheral route to persuasion, but it can be used effectively on almost anyone.

People with Heightened Resistance A persuasive message can become ineffective if people can generate arguments against it. For example, *simply informing subjects a few minutes ahead of time that they are about to hear a persuasive speech on a certain topic weakens the effect of the talk on their attitudes* (Petty & Cacioppo, 1977). This tendency is called the **forewarning effect**.

With the **inoculation effect**, *people first hear a weak argument, then a stronger argument supporting the same conclusion*. After they have rejected the first argument, they



Grigory Rasputin was a contemptible person. However, people who are told he resembled them, even in trivial ways, soften their criticisms.

are likely to reject the second one also. In one experiment, subjects listened to speeches *against* brushing their teeth after every meal. Some of them heard just a strong argument (for example, “Brushing your teeth too frequently wears away tooth enamel, leading to serious disease”). Others first heard a weak argument, then the strong argument 2 days later. Still others first heard an argument *for* toothbrushing, then the strong argument against it. Only the subjects who heard the weak antibrushing argument before the strong one resisted its influence; the other two groups found it highly persuasive (McGuire & Papageorgis, 1961). So, if you want to convince someone, present some good evidence first; don't start with evidence that they may consider faulty.

CONCEPT CHECK

7. If you want your children to preserve the beliefs and attitudes you try to teach them, should you give them only arguments that support those beliefs or should you also expose them to attacks on those beliefs? Why? (Check your answer on page 533.)

Strategies of Persuasion

Many people, ranging from salespeople selling worthless products to people representing noble charities, will sometimes ask you to give more of your time or money

than you would rationally choose to spend. You should understand several of their techniques so that you can resist these appeals.

One technique is to make a modest request at first and then to follow it with a larger second request. This procedure is called the **foot-in-the-door technique**. When Jonathan Freedman and Scott Fraser (1966) asked suburban residents in Palo Alto, California, to put a small “Drive Safely” sign in their window, most of them agreed to do so. A couple of weeks later, other researchers asked the same residents to let them set up a large, unsightly “Drive Safely” billboard in their front yard for 10 days. They made the same request to a group of residents that had not been approached by the first group of researchers. Of those who had already agreed to display the small sign, 76% agreed to let them set up the billboard. Only 17% of the others agreed. Even agreeing to make as small a commitment as signing a petition to support a cause significantly increases the probability that people will later donate money to that cause (Schwarzwald, Bizman, & Raz, 1983).

In another approach, called the **door-in-the-face technique** (Cialdini et al., 1975), *someone follows an outrageous initial request with a much more reasonable second one*, implying that, if you refused the first request, you should at least compromise by agreeing to the second one. For example, I once received a telephone call from a college alumni association, asking me to show my loyalty by contributing \$1,000. When I apologetically declined, the caller acted sympathetic (as if to say, “It’s too bad you don’t have a high-paying job like all our other alumni . . .”) and then asked whether I could contribute \$500. And if not \$500, how about \$200? And so forth. The implication was that, if I had refused the original request, I should “compromise” by giving a smaller amount.

Robert Cialdini and his colleagues (1975) demonstrated the power of the door-in-the-face technique with a clever experiment. They asked one group of college students, chosen randomly, whether they would be willing to chaperone a group from the juvenile detention center on a trip to the zoo. Only 17% said they would. They asked other students to spend 2 hours per week for 2 years working as counselors with juvenile delinquents. Not surprisingly, all of them refused. But then the researchers asked them, “If you won’t do that, would you chaperone a group from the juvenile detention center on one trip to the zoo?” Half of them said they would. Apparently, they felt that the researchers were conceding a great deal and that it was only fair to meet them halfway.

Someone using the **lowball technique** *first offers an extremely favorable deal and then makes additional demands after the other person has committed to the deal* (Cialdini, 1993). For example, a car dealer offers you an exceptionally good price on a new car and a most generous price for the trade-in of your old car. You weren’t sure you wanted this make of car, but the deal is too good to resist. After you have committed yourself to buying this car, the

dealer checks with the boss, who rejects the deal. Your salesperson comes back saying, “I’m so sorry. I forgot that this car has some special features that raise the value. If we sold it for the price I originally quoted, we’d lose money.” So you agree to a higher price. Then the company’s used car specialist looks at your old car and “corrects” the trade-in value to a lower amount. Still, you have already committed yourself, so you don’t back out. Eventually, you leave with a deal that you would probably not have accepted at the start.

In the **that’s-not-all technique**, *someone makes an offer and then improves the offer before anyone has a chance to reply*. The television announcer says, “Here’s your chance to buy this amazing combination paper shredder and coffeemaker for only \$39.95. But wait, there’s more! We’ll throw in a can of dog deodorant! And this handy windshield wiper cleaner and a subscription to *Modern Lobotomist*! And if you act now, you can get this amazing offer, which usually costs \$39.95, for only \$19.95! Call this number!” People who hear the first offer and then the “improved” offer are more likely to comply than are people who first hear the “improved” offer (Burger, 1986).

CONCEPT CHECK

8. Identify each of the following as an example of the foot-in-the-door technique, the door-in-the-face technique, or the that’s-not-all technique.
 - a. Your boss says, “We need to cut costs drastically around here. I’m afraid I’m going to have to cut your salary in half.” You protest vigorously. Your boss replies, “Well, I suppose we could cut expenses some other way. Maybe I can give you just a 5% cut.” “Thanks,” you reply. “I can live with that.”
 - b. A store marks its prices “25% off,” then scratches that out and marks them “50% off!” Though the prices are now about the same as at competing stores, customers flock into the store.
 - c. A friend asks you to help carry some supplies over to the elementary school for an afternoon tutoring program. When you get there, the principal says that one of the tutors is late and asks whether you could take her place until she arrives. You agree and spend the rest of the afternoon tutoring. The principal then talks you into coming back every week as a tutor. (Check your answers on page 533.)

Cognitive Dissonance

On page 561, we considered whether a change in people’s attitudes will change their behavior. The theory of cognitive dissonance reverses the direction: It holds that, when people’s behavior changes, their attitudes will change (Festinger, 1957).

Cognitive dissonance is a state of unpleasant tension that people experience when they hold contradictory attitudes or when their behavior is inconsistent with their attitudes, especially if they perceive this inconsistency as a threat to their self-esteem. For example, if you pride yourself on honesty and find yourself saying something you do not believe, you feel tension. You can reduce that tension in three ways: You can change what you are saying to match your attitudes, change your attitude to match what you are saying, or adopt an explanation that justifies your behavior under the circumstances (Wicklund & Brehm, 1976). (See Figure 14.4.) Although you might adopt any of these options, most of the existing research has focused on how cognitive dissonance changes people's attitudes.

Evidence Favoring the Cognitive Dissonance Theory

Leon Festinger and J. Merrill Carlsmith (1959) carried out the following classic experiment on cognitive dissonance. Imagine yourself as one of the participants. The experimenters explain that they are studying motor behavior. They show you a board full of pegs. Your task is to take each peg out of the board, rotate it one-fourth of a turn, and return it to the board. When you finish all the pegs, you start over from the top, rotating all the pegs again as quickly and accurately as possible. . . for an hour. As you proceed, an experimenter silently takes notes. You find your task tedious and boring.

At the end of the hour, the experimenter thanks you for participating and “explains” to you (falsely) that the study's purpose was to determine whether people's performances are influenced by their attitudes toward the task. You were in the neutral-attitude group, but those in the positive-attitude group are told before they start that this will be an enjoyable, interesting experience. In fact, the experimenter continues, right now the research assistant is supposed to give that instruction to the next participant, a young woman waiting in the next room. The experimenter excuses himself to find the research assistant and then returns distraught. The assistant is nowhere to be found, he says. He turns to you and asks, “Would you be willing to tell the next subject that you thought this was an interesting, enjoyable experiment? If so, I will pay you.”

Assume that you consent, as most students in the study did. After you tell that woman in the next room that you enjoyed the study, what would you actually think of the study, assuming the experimenter paid you \$1? What if he paid you \$20? (This study occurred in the 1950s, before decades of inflation. In today's money, that \$20 would be worth more than \$100.)

In the actual study, after participants told the woman how much fun this experiment was, they left, believing the study was over. As they walked down the hall, they were met by a representative of the psychology department who explained that the department wanted to find out what kinds

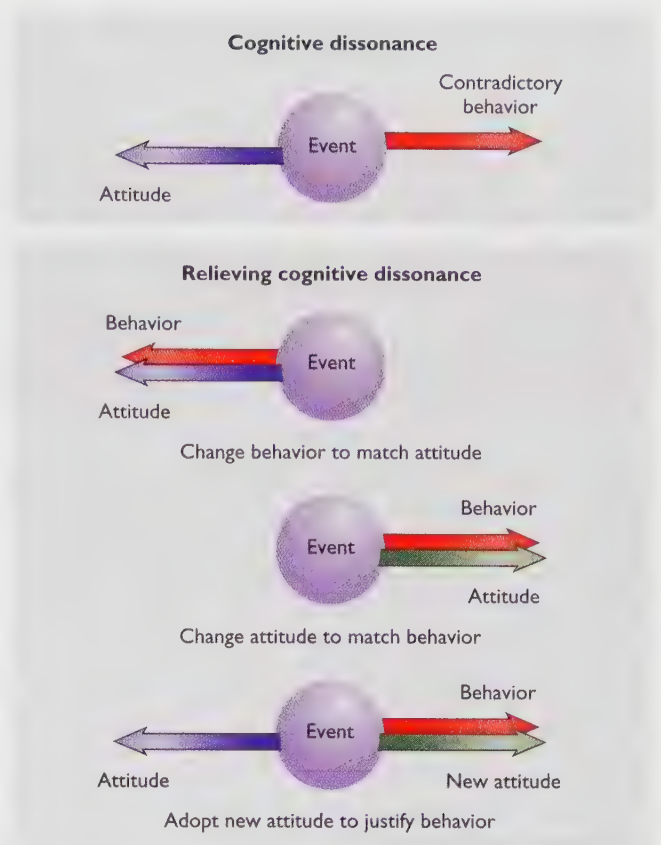


FIGURE 14.4 Cognitive dissonance is a state of tension that arises when people perceive that their attitudes do not match their behavior. Theoretically, they could resolve this discrepancy by changing either their attitudes or their behavior, or by developing a new attitude or excuse to explain the discrepancy. Most of the research, however, has focused on how cognitive dissonance leads to a change of attitude.

of experiments were being conducted and whether they were educationally worthwhile. (The answers to these questions were the real point of the experiment.) Participants were asked how enjoyable they considered the experiment to be and whether they would be willing to participate in a similar experiment later.

The students who received \$20 said they thought the experiment was boring and that they wanted nothing to do with another such experiment. However, contrary to what you might guess, those who received just \$1 said they enjoyed the experiment and would be willing to participate again (Figure 14.5).

Why? According to the theory of cognitive dissonance, those who accepted \$20 to tell a lie experienced little conflict. They knew they were lying, but they also knew why: for the \$20. They had no reason to change their original opinion of the experiment—that they had been bored to tears. However, the students who had told a lie for only \$1 felt a conflict between their true attitude toward the boring experiment and what they had said about it. The small payment provided little reason for lying, so they experienced

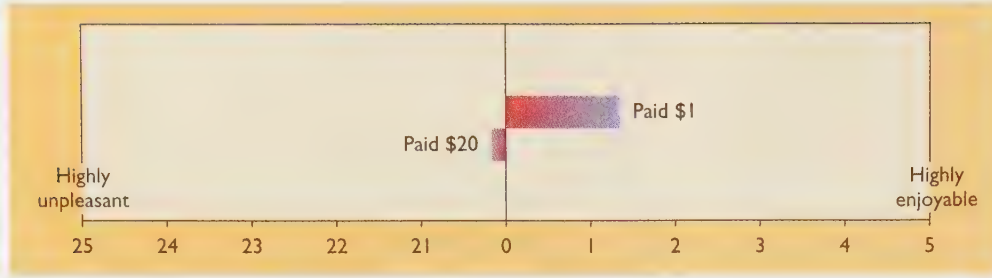


FIGURE 14.5 In a classic experiment demonstrating cognitive dissonance, subjects were paid either \$1 or \$20 for telling another subject that they enjoyed an experiment (which was actually boring). Later, they were asked for their real opinions. Those subjects who were paid the smaller amount said that they enjoyed the study more than the others. (Based on data from Festinger & Carlsmith, 1959.)

cognitive dissonance—an unpleasant tension. They did not want to feel bad about telling a lie, so the only way they could reduce their tension was to change their attitude, to decide that the experiment really had been interesting after all. (“I learned a lot of interesting things about myself, like . . . uh . . . how good I am at rotating pegs.”)

The idea of cognitive dissonance attracted much attention and inspired a great deal of research in the 1960s and 1970s (Aronson, 1997). Two representative examples:

- An experimenter left a child in a room with toys but forbade the child to play with one particular toy. If the experimenter threatened the child with severe punishment for playing with the toy, the child avoided it but still regarded it as desirable. However, if the experimenter merely said that he or she would be unhappy or disappointed if the child played with that toy, the child avoided the toy and said (even weeks later) that it was not a good toy (Aronson & Carlsmith, 1963).
- The experimenter asked college students to write an essay defending a position that the experimenter knew, from previous information, was contrary to the students’ actual beliefs. For example, college students who favored freer access to alcohol might be asked to write essays on why the college should increase restrictions on alcohol. Those who were told they must write the essays did not change their views significantly, but those who were asked to “please” write the essay but were also reminded that they did so voluntarily generally came to agree with what they wrote (Croyle & Cooper, 1983).

Some people are more likely than others to alter their attitudes as a result of cognitive dissonance. A few studies have found weaker cognitive dissonance effects in Japanese than in North American people, perhaps because the Japanese are more accustomed to subordinating their own attitudes to do what someone else asks of them (Heine & Lehman, 1997).

The general principle is that, if you ask people to do something they would not otherwise do, by means of a minimum reward or a tiny threat, so that they are acting voluntarily or almost voluntarily, they will change their attitudes to defend what they are doing to reduce cognitive dissonance. This procedure is a particularly powerful way of changing people’s attitudes because people are actively participating, not just quietly listening to someone else explain

the reasons for an opinion. You have probably heard people say, “If you want to change people’s behavior, you have to change their attitudes first.” The results of cognitive dissonance experiments tell us quite the opposite: If you start by changing people’s behavior, their attitudes will change too.

CONCEPT CHECKS

9. Suppose your parents pay you to get a good grade in a course that you consider boring. According to cognitive dissonance theory, are you more likely to develop a positive attitude toward your studies if your parents pay you \$10 or \$100?
10. The effort to avoid cognitive dissonance leads to consistency in behavior. Use that principle to explain the foot-in-the-door technique. (Check your answers on pages 533, 534.)

THE MESSAGE Attitudes, Persuasion, and Manipulation

When you are forming an attitude toward something of little consequence to you, it is understandable that you will follow the peripheral route, paying little attention to the complexities of the evidence. When you are dealing with important matters, however, such as how you will spend your time and money, or who to choose for your partner in life, you will almost certainly follow the central route, examining the facts as carefully as you can. It is important to be alert to some of the influences that might throw you off course, such as the foot-in-the-door technique, lowballing, and cognitive dissonance. Advertisers, politicians, and vast numbers of others are trying to polish their techniques of persuasion, and not everyone has your best interest at heart.

SUMMARY

- ★ *Attitudes.* An attitude is a like or dislike of something or somebody that influences our behavior toward that thing or person. (page 524)

- ★ *Two routes to persuasion.* When people are considering an appeal regarding a topic of little importance, they are easily persuaded by the speaker's appearance and other superficial factors, regardless of the strength or weakness of the evidence. When people consider an appeal on a matter of importance to them, they pay more attention to logic and to the quality of the evidence. (page 525)
- ★ *Resistant attitudes.* On a few topics, such as the death penalty, many people form entrenched attitudes that are based on little real information. (page 525)
- ★ *Sleeper effect.* When people reject a message because of their low regard for the person who proposed it, they sometimes forget where they heard the idea and later come to accept it. (page 527)
- ★ *Minority influence.* Although a minority may have little influence at first, it can, through persistent repetition of its message, eventually persuade the majority to adopt its position or to consider other alternatives. (page 527)
- ★ *Influence of fear-inducing messages.* Whether messages that appeal to fear prove effective depends on whether people perceive the danger as real and whether they think they can do anything about it. (page 527)
- ★ *Forewarning and inoculation effects.* People evaluate the reasoning behind the persuasive messages they hear. If they have been warned that someone will try to persuade them of something, or if they have previously heard a weak version of the persuasive argument, they tend to resist the argument more strongly than they otherwise would have. (page 529)
- ★ *Strategies of persuasion.* Several procedures can influence people to do something they would not have done, if asked directly. These include starting with a tiny request and then increasing it, starting with an enormous request and offering to compromise, offering a generous deal and then demanding more, and offering a moderate deal and then adding inducements. (page 529)
- ★ *Cognitive dissonance.* Cognitive dissonance is a state of unpleasant tension that arises from contradictory attitudes or from behavior that conflicts with a person's attitudes. When people's behavior does not match their attitudes, they try to eliminate the inconsistency by changing either their behavior or their attitudes. (page 530)

Suggestion for Further Reading

Petty, R. E., & Cacioppo, J. T. (1996). *Attitudes and persuasion: Classic and contemporary approaches* (2nd ed). Dubuque, IA: Times Mirror Higher Education. A complete yet readable review of research on attitudes and attitude change.

Terms

- attitude** a like or dislike that influences our behavior toward a person or thing (page 524)
- high self-monitor** a person who constantly monitors his or her own behavior to try to behave in what others consider an appropriate manner for each situation (page 525)

- central route to persuasion** a method of persuasion based on careful evaluation of evidence and logic (page 525)
- peripheral route to persuasion** a method of persuasion based on such superficial factors as the speaker's appearance and reputation or the sheer number of arguments presented, regardless of their quality (page 525)
- sleeper effect** delayed persuasion by an initially rejected message (page 527)
- forewarning effect** the tendency of a brief preview of a message to decrease its persuasiveness (page 529)
- inoculation effect** the tendency of a persuasive message to be weakened if people first hear a weak argument supporting the same conclusion (page 529)
- foot-in-the-door technique** a method of eliciting compliance by first making a modest request and then following it with a larger request (page 530)
- door-in-the-face technique** a method of eliciting compliance by first making an outrageous request and then replying to the refusal with a more reasonable request (page 530)
- lowball technique** the procedure of first offering an extremely favorable deal and then making additional demands after the other person has committed to the deal (page 530)
- that's-not-all technique** a method of eliciting compliance whereby someone makes an offer and then improves the offer before anyone has a chance to reply (page 530)
- cognitive dissonance** a state of unpleasant tension that people experience when they hold contradictory attitudes or when their behavior is inconsistent with their attitudes, especially if they perceive this inconsistency as a threat to their self-esteem (page 531)

Answers to Concept Checks

4. The attitudes of low self-monitors will more often match their behavior. High self-monitors are more likely to do what they think is expected of them, independent of their attitudes. (page 525)
5. You will pay more attention to the evidence and logic, following the central route to persuasion, for the decision about your major. (page 525)
6. The fact that your idea was overwhelmingly rejected does not mean that you should give up. If you and a few allies continue to present this plan in a simple way, showing apparent agreement among yourselves, the majority may eventually endorse a similar plan—but probably without giving you credit for suggesting the idea. (page 527)
7. You should expose them to weak attacks on their beliefs so that they will learn how to resist such attacks. Otherwise, they will be like children who grow up in a germ-free environment: They will develop no “immunity” and will thus be vulnerable when their beliefs are attacked. (page 529)
8. **a.** Door-in-the-face technique; **b.** that's-not-all technique; **c.** foot-in-the-door technique. (page 530)
9. You will come to like your studies more if you are paid \$10 than if you are paid \$100. If you are paid only \$10, you won't be able to tell yourself that you are studying harder only for the money. Instead, you will tell yourself that you must be really interested. The theory of intrinsic and extrinsic motivation leads to the same prediction: If you study hard in the absence of any strong external reason, you will perceive that you have internal reasons for studying. (page 532)

10. Once you have agreed to a small request, you can maintain consistency (decrease dissonance) by agreeing to similar requests in the future. (page 532)

Web Resources

Cognitive Dissonance Theory

ccwf.cc.utexas.edu/~benj/patty/

A student paper describes cognitive dissonance and lists techniques for reducing dissonance, with help from Calvin and Hobbs.

Cognitive Dissonance

thanatos.uoregon.edu/~galahad/cogdiss.html

A student examines "The Role of Cognitive Dissonance in Decision Making."

Interpersonal Attraction

How do people choose their friends?

How do people select their romantic partners?

William Proxmire, a former U.S. senator, used to give “Golden Fleece Awards” to those who, in his opinion, most flagrantly wasted the taxpayers’ money. He once bestowed an award on some psychologists who had received a federal grant to study how people fall in love. According to Proxmire, the research was pointless because people do not want to understand love. They prefer, he said, to let such matters remain a mystery.

This module presents the information Senator Proxmire thought you did not want to know.

People’s Need for One Another

Think back to your first week at college. Did you feel lonely? Maybe not, if you went to the same college as some close friends, or if you made some good friends rapidly. But

many college students do feel lonely at the start. If you did, you may have spent hours on the telephone with friends and family back home, or you may have worked hard at establishing new friendships.

Clearly, people crave close, long-term relationships with other people. We have a “need to belong,” to identify with a family or close group of friends and to be able to talk with someone about personal, confidential matters (Collins & Miller, 1994). Why? Some psychologists have proposed that we learn this need from our early experiences with a nurturing parent. I shall not deny the importance of early nurturing experiences, but those experiences do not fully explain our strong social needs. If they did, we would find similar social needs in all other mammalian species. Bears, humans, porcupines, deer, and all the rest start life with a nurturing mother-infant relationship; nevertheless, some species develop a rich social life and some do not (Figure 14.6). Humans’ need for social relationships might therefore best be regarded as a basic need, a part of our biological nature (Baumeister & Leary, 1995).

Besides lasting relationships, we sometimes cultivate temporary friends for a limited purpose. For example, you might want to get together with other students in a particular class to study for a test, or you might get together with a group for recreational sports.

Brief, casual affiliations can also be important to us for our own self-understanding. If you have just had an intense and trying emotional experience, you might want to be with other people who have had a similar experience, to compare your reactions to theirs and (you hope) demonstrate that you coped with the experience at least as well as they did (Kruglanski & Mayseless, 1990). People also like to associate with people who can set a good example. For example, cancer patients generally like to associate with other cancer patients, especially patients who are showing signs of recovery and who can thus provide an encouraging role model (Taylor & Lobel, 1989).

When people expect to face a difficult experience in the near future, they generally like to be with other people



FIGURE 14.6 Although all mammalian species start life with a nurturing mother-infant relationship, some species become highly social and some do not. Humans are among the highly social species. Evidently, our tendency to be social is part of our basic nature.